

Technical Report Writing (TRW)

**Chapters No 19
Letters**

Chapter in a Nutshell

- Letter types
- Three basic letter formats
- Elements of letters

Letter types

Formal letters also called business letters represent the writer and the firm and their quality reflects the quality of the firm. There are two major divisions of formal letters or business letters.

Transmittal letters: It conveys a report from one firm to another. A transmittal letter should contain the following points.

- The title of the report
- A statement of when it was requested
- A very general statement of the report's purpose and scope
- Mentioning of the problems encountered (if there were any)
- An acknowledgement of those who were particularly helpful in assembling the report

General Information Letters

All those letters which are not transmittal letters are called general information letters and these letters can deal with anything other than transmitting a report like keeping the writer and the reader in touch, public relations, sending information or to reply to requests and so on.

- The writer should use a context setting introduction.
- If there is an acceptance or rejection, state it clearly.
- Use formatting devices to highlight the main points.
- Add extra information as needed, but keep it brief.

Basic Formats of letters

- **Block format**: Place all the elements of letter flushed against the left margin. Do not indent the first word of each paragraph. It is widely used in formal business letter writing as it can be quickly typed.
- **Modified Block Format**: It is the same as the block format, with two exceptions; the dateline and closing signature are placed on the right side of the page. If we indent the first word of the first line of each paragraph five spaces, then it is called modified semi-block format.
- **Simplified Format**: It contains no salutation and no complimentary closing, but it almost always has a subject line. It is suitable for impersonal situations.

Elements of a letter

These are the elements of a letter from the top to the bottom of a page.

1. Heading. It is the address of the writer of the letter
2. Date. Can be written in two forms: June 25, 2020 or 25 June 2020
3. Inside Address. It is the same as is on the envelope; address of recipient.
4. Attention Line. It is used to avoid the awkward situation, when the writer cannot name the reader,. 'Attention Recruitment Manager'.
5. Salutation. It always agrees with the first line of the inside address.
6. Subject Line. Used to focus the reader's attention on the subject of the letter and can also be used to play the role of attention line. Never use these together. Either the attention line or the subject line is used. Colon is used after the word subject but attention line is written directly.
7. Body. It is written in several chunks, in the light of chapter 4. In letters I, we and you should be used, consider your audience and use plain English.
8. Complimentary closing and signature. Close business letters with 'Sincerely' or 'Sincerely yours' and sign above your name.

Some terms to remember

- Indentation. When only the first word of only the first line of a new chunk or para is placed 5 spaces or one tab towards the right side, it is called indentation.
- Gender Neutral. Whenever name of a person is written without a title on the left side, it is said to be in gender neutral.
- Personal Title. Any title written on the left side of the name of any person like (Mr. Ms. Mrs. Dr. Engr. Maj. Col. Prof.)
- Business Title. Any title written on the right side or below the name of any person like Dr. S Kamran Afaq, Dean E&T (Dr. is personal title and Dean is the Business title) Dr. Liaqat Ali, HOD MED (Dr. is personal title and HOD is business title)
- Ordinal Indication. When we write 1st 2nd 3rd 4th the letters with the digits is ordinal indication and it should be avoided. Especially in date writing, use the two ways discussed before in the elements slide.